CHAPTER 10

Functions and Classifications

OF THE ZODIACAL SIGNS

THE ZODIACAL SIGNS SERVE THREE PRIMARY FUNCTIONS IN THE OVERALL structure and internal integrity of the birth chart:

1. as *images* that shape behaviors and physical characteristics
2. as *configurations* which act as a network of familial relationships
3. as *residences* which provide resources and powers

The broad brushstrokes of this organization reflect in part the social customs of the Hellenistic world, where there were clear rules and distinctions establishing one's position in the network of alliances and enmities and the various ways in which wealth, resources, and power were distributed.

Hellenistic astrologers often used two Greek words, *zōidion* and *oikos*, when writing about the zodiacal signs. *Zōidion* means a small image of a living thing, and *oikos* means a home or dwelling place. These two notions about the zodiacal signs can be traced back to the second millennium BCE Babylonian creation myth, the *Enuma Elish*:

> He [Marduk] constructed stations for the great gods,
> Fixing their astral likenesses (*images*) as the stars of the Zodiac.
> He determined the year and into sections he divided it;
> He set up three constellations for each of the twelve months.[1]

This verse suggests that the images of the constellations were set up as the dwelling places for the planetary gods, and these stellar images marked each segment of the twelve-month year.

1 *Enuma Elish* v. 1–4. Translation by E. A. SPEISER in *Ancient Near Eastern Texts Relating to the Old Testament*, 3rd edition, edited by James PRITCHARD (Princeton, 1969).

malefics are in collusion? For example, Mars and Saturn at any degree of Sagittarius, both hurling square rays at Venus at any degree of Virgo, would qualify as maltreatment by hurling rays.

2. A single malefic in an inferior square can maltreat another planet by hurling a whole sign ray, regardless of degree. That is exceptional power. If this were the case, it redefines whole sign testimony as well as obfuscating the power of maltreatment by connection (*sunaphē*). And it throws into doubt the strength of the superior overcoming planet.

3. The inferior planet must not only hurl a backwards ray by whole sign, it must also strike the other planet by degree. We could safely assume a 3° applying orb, so the planet being maltreated runs into the malefic ray hurled slightly ahead of it, much like a bird flying into an arrow shot by a hunter just ahead of its flight path. This necessitates that the planet hurling the ray is the slower planet, striking the faster planet running into its hurled ray. However, this equates to maltreatment by connection (*sunaphē*), which is a separate condition; it also involves planetary speed, which is not part of the right and left distinctions with which we are working.

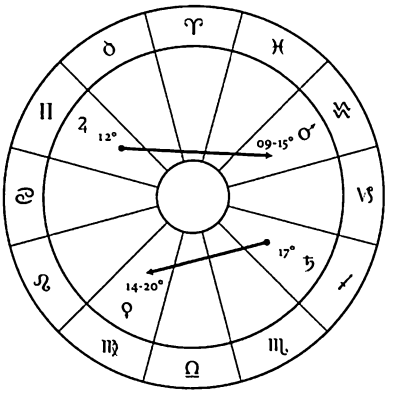


FIGURE 74.
MALTREATMENT & BONIFICATION
BY STRIKING WITH A RAY
Jupiter bonifies Mars by hurling a trine ray.
Saturn maltreats Venus by hurling a square ray.

4. According to Valens, there is a 3° range on either side of the planet that is vulnerable to destruction when being struck by a backward hurled ray.[1] If this is the case, a malefic planet can hurl a backward square ray at another planet, and maltreatment would occur if that ray should strike the planet within a 3° orb on either side (thus a 7° range altogether). Saturn at 17° Sagittarius, for example, would hurl a square ray at Venus in Virgo (who could be located from 14–20°). This interpretation of maltreatment by striking with

1 VALENS, Anthology 3.3. Valens also instructs that benefics that hurl rays within this 3° interval on either side become "preventers of destruction".